As early as 8 a.m. on the policy day, OB vans park outside the Reserve Bank central office with reporters from TV channels and wire agencies milling around and sending live feeds from the scene of action. There is understandably competition among TV channels to ‘be the first with the policy’ which entails the risk of the first outburst of comment being incoherent or even ill-informed. To mitigate this risk, the Reserve Bank provides privileged access of the policy statement to reporters in advance with a strictly enforced embargo protocol.

At 9 a.m., these privileged reporters are conducted into the ‘embargo room’ where they surrender their cell phones and data cards and settle down in front of their systems sans any communication tools. A Reserve Bank official reads out the embargo rules, including a clause that once the policy document is given to them, they cannot leave the room even to use the loo! As soon as the statement is handed over, the room turns into an examination hall. All one can hear is the shuffle of papers and the click of keyboards as they prepare their headlines and stories while a hawk-eyed Reserve Bank staffer keeps a close watch on them.

Moments before 11 a.m., the Reserve Bank staffer gets an alert and the countdown begins: ‘5-4-3-2-1-Go.’ The policy is announced—simultaneously on the Reserve Bank website and on TV screens and wire agency channels. But there is time enough only to give quick headlines before they rush for the governor’s media conference.

A few minutes before the release time, the deputy governors, the monetary policy team and I would gather in my office on the eighteenth floor, watching the TV of course, and much like actors in a play, wait for the cue to enter the stage. When the alert comes, we would troop down three floors in the express elevator, go through the photo op with cameras clicking and bulbs flashing, and then enter the conference room for the media interaction.

Early on in my tenure, I used to start the media conference by reading a short, prepared statement but found that pattern to be too stilted. After a few meetings, I abandoned the practice in favour of an informal opening briefing after which we would get into conversation. Even as I thought I